Tibetan Scripts Identification Guide

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By Penpok W. Kesang

A 3-Step Process for Identifying Tibetan Scripts

The 3-step process for identifying Tibetan scripts is a simple but effective method to identify any literal Tibetan scripts into 5 general script categories: Uchan དབུ་ཅན།, Druma འབྲུ་མ།, Danyig ལྡན་ཡིག, Tsugdri ཚུགས་རིས།, and Cursives རྒྱུ་ཡིག. Of the five, the last four can be classified as Ume དབུ་མེད།.

The 1st Step:

Identify whether a script is Uchan or Ume. Simply, those with a head bar are Uchan དབུ་ཅན།, and those that eliminate the head bar are Ume དབུ་མེད།.

The 2nd Step:

Identify different Ume scripts. Ume Scripts can be simplified into four major categories:

1. Those with an **oval** or round shape are **Druma**
2. Those with a **semi-oval** shape are **Danyig**
3. Those with a **rectangular** shape are **Tsugdri**.

   Two key letters to identify the shapes of letters can be ཀ and བ།.

   Two vowel signs to look at to aid the classification are gigu (I ཱི) and naro (O ཿ).
4. Running scripts and cursives.

The 3rd Step:

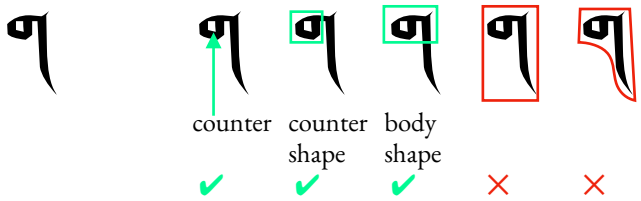
Identify the height of the scripts, which is determined by the length of the descenders or legs. The letters with long descenders are: ཀ་ཁ་ཁ་དཀ་ཁ་ཀ

The height variable significantly impacts the script's real-world use case:

1. The styles with little to no legs are mainly used for writing large volumes of text.
2. The styles with short-to-medium-length descenders are used for body text, often with interlinears and comments.
3. The styles with long legs are used for luxurious manuscript production, decrees, and titles.

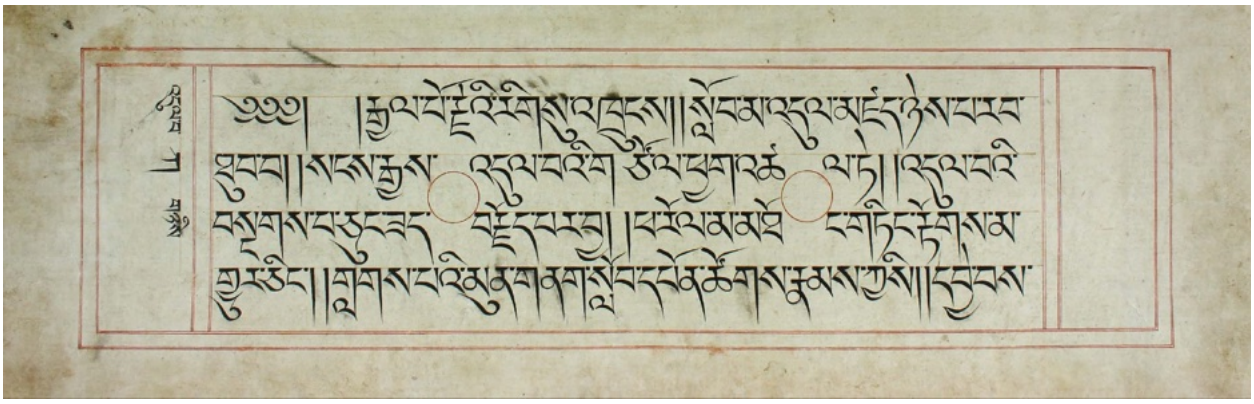
As a result, the names of the script styles based on the height must be used to name a script style and not the three categorical terms above.

Note: the **shape** here refers either to the shapes of the counters (white spaces in letters) or the shape of the letter-body and NOT the shapewith the whole body, including the legs of the letters, as shown below with the example using the letter *ga*:

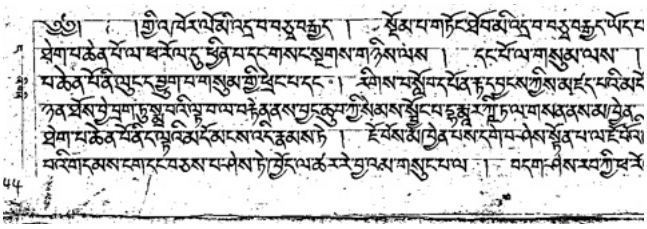


Uchan, the Headed Script

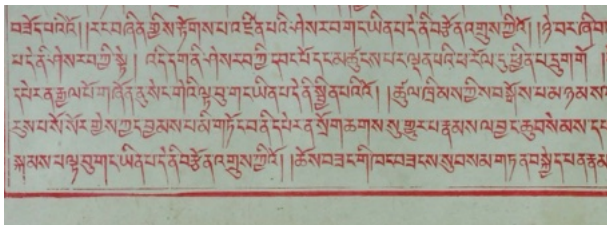
Most of the Tibetan texts and books you would see are written or printed in **Uchan**, as it has the best readability. Uchan comes in various heights, for which the tall ones are called **Sugring**, and the short ones are called **Sugthung**. The height is determined by the length of the legs or descenders. It also comes with different weights, determined by the thickness of the strokes. The bold ones are called **Shachen**, while the light ones are called **Shachung**. While Tibetan does not make upper or lower case scripts, it does distinguish between the two with size. As such, the large ones are called **Zabchen**, and the small ones are called **Zabchung**.



Prime example of Uchan on a Pecha (book). Medium or regular length of legs, in Large Printscript or Zabchen.



Short-legged Uchan or **Sugthung**



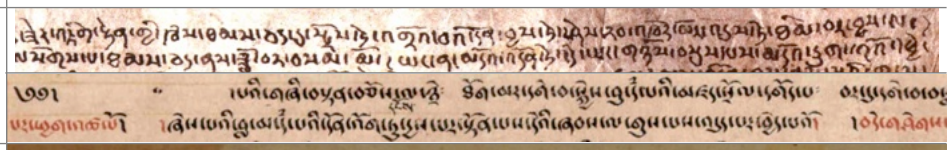
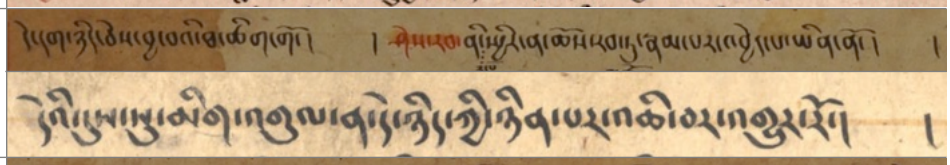
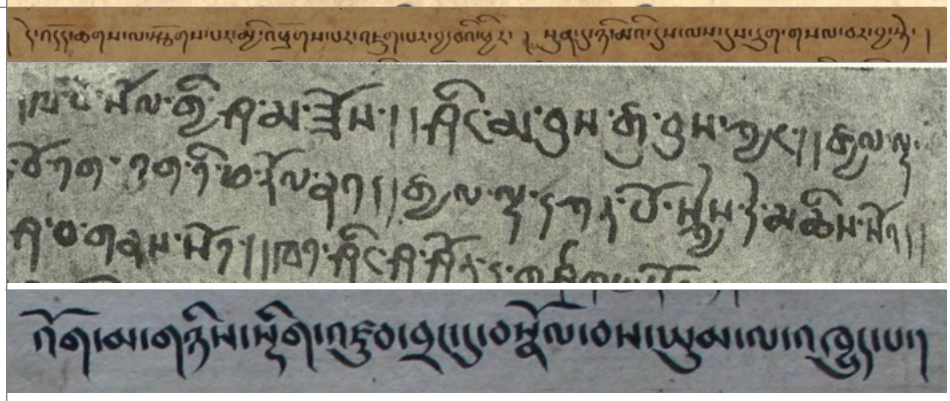
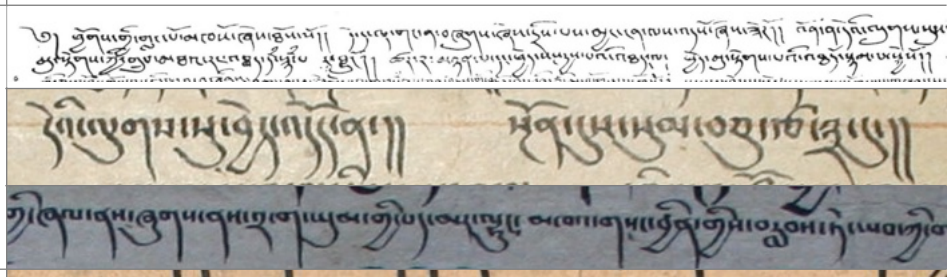
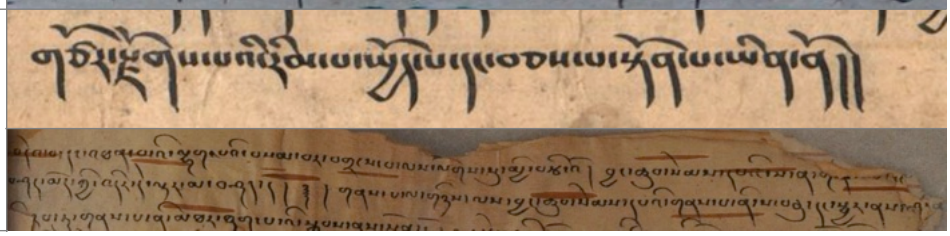
Long-legged Uchan or **Sugring** on a woodblock

Ume, The Headless Scripts

The different Ume script shapes include **oval, semi-oval, rectangle, square,** and **oblong**. These shapes form specific script groups with multiple styles. For the running scripts, the shapes become less obvious, and their cursive nature appears dominant. Thus, there are several running letters and cursive styles based on their speed or degree of cursivization. The vowel sign **gigu** remains a main identifier, which is completely looped, and its angle increases as the speed of writing increases, exceeding 90 degrees in cursives.

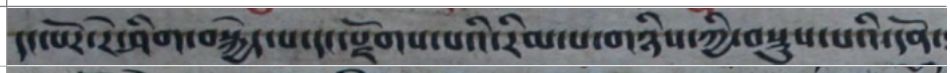
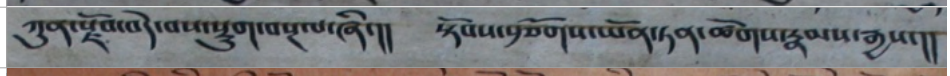
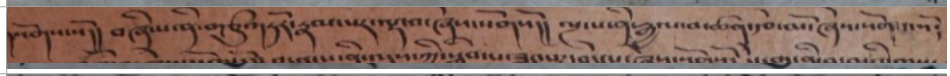
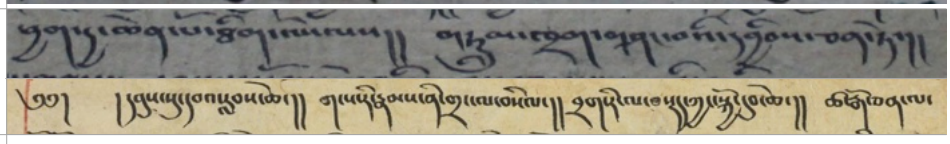
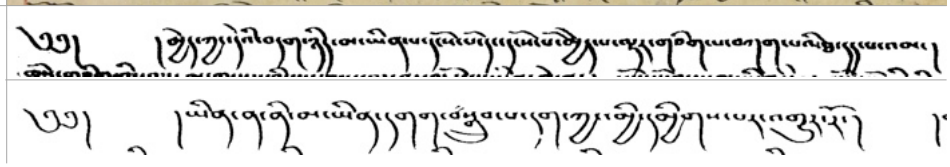
Druma, the Oval Script

Counter shape	Oval **O 0**
Gigu	looks like the Uchan gigu or closer to the Uchan gigu
Naro	**with both strokes (wings)**
Descender length	range from legless to tall

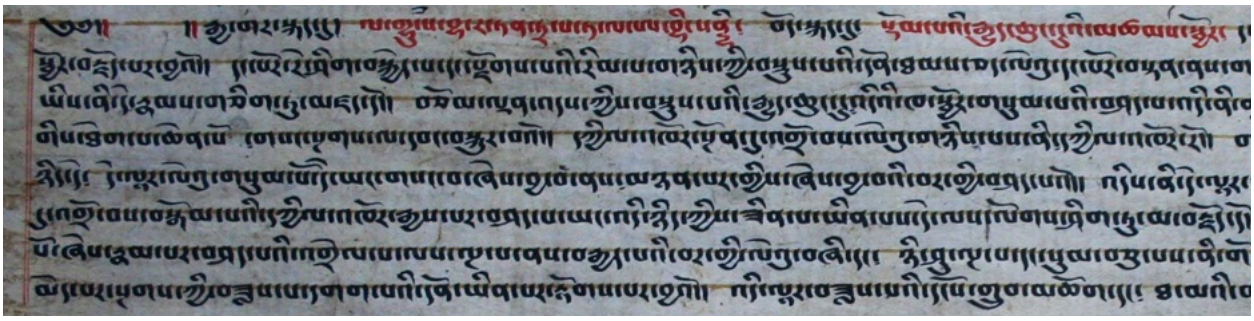
Script style	Identifier Sample
Dhumri (Oval Hand)	
Druma Sugthung (Short Oval Hand)	
Druma	
Druma Sugring (Tall Oval Hand)	
Druchen	

Danyig: The Semi-Oval Script

Counter shape	Semi-Oval
Gigu	**Circular to flat**
Naro	**Wavy** (written with one stroke)
Descender length	Varies from legless to extra tall
Overall	Versatile script with **option to be scribed swiftly**

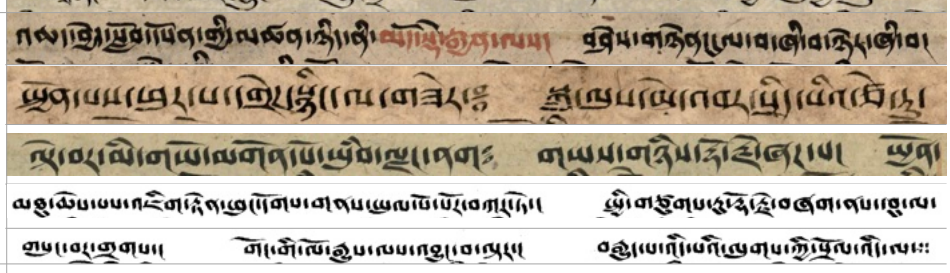
Script style	Identifier Sample
Tsegdrig	
Danthung	
Danyig	
Danyig Sugring	
Gongshabma	

Drari looks like Druma but is written faster, resulting in its versatile form.



Tsugdri: The Stylish Scripts

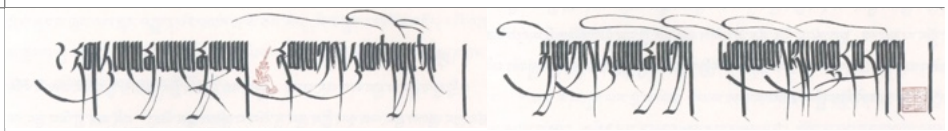
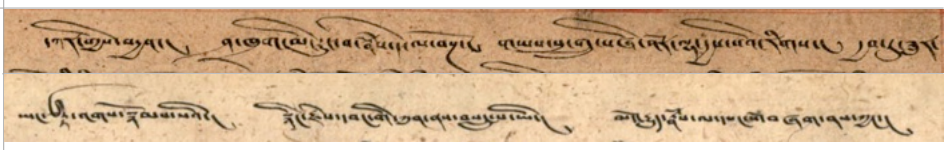
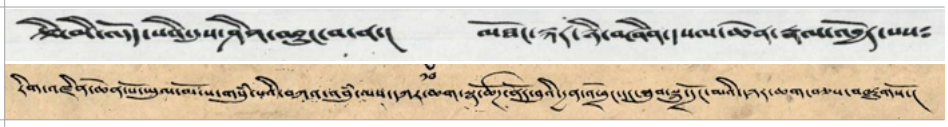
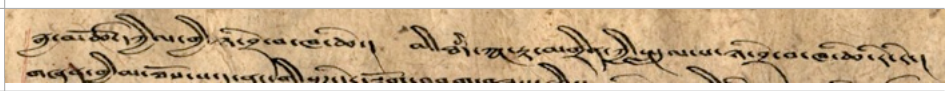
Counter shape	Rectangular ▯ ☐
Gigu	Similar to the gigu of Druma
Naro	A flat, **stylish line**
Overall	The main book hand since a few centuries ago

Script style	Identifier Sample
Peri (Book Hand)	
Petsug (Book Style)	

Petsug is the latest form and the mainstream Book Hand, while in older literature it is known as **Peri**. There is a slight difference in terms of the width and shape. Peri tends to be more condensed and narrow, while Petsug tends to be more squarish in shape and more extended in width. If possible, it is best to make this distinction, but if not, Petsug is the mainstream term nowadays.

The Current Mainstream Tsugdri— Stylish Hands

Counter shape	**Oblong** the shape gets flattened as the size reduces
Gigu	Completely **looped**, with an angle **lower than 30 degrees.**
Naro	A flat, stylish line
Overall	The main Ume pedagogical order that decrees from the largest to the smallest size

Script style	Identifier Sample
Tsugring	
Tsugthung	
Tsugchung	
	Tsumakhyuk goes here, but it is provided in the next section, as it is a runing script
Trinyig	

Tsugring (Tall Style) is a purely pedagogical script that is taught to beginners; it is not supposed to be used in actual writing, although some titles are scribed in Tsugring. The Tusgring sample is included as these styles range from the largest to the smallest, with Tsugring being the biggest; the basic letterforms for these styles are the same. However, the reduction in size and the definition of the script style result in subtle differences in the styles. For example, the Tsugring and Tsugthung (Short Style) gigu have the lowest angles, with rounded looping ends, while the **Tsugthung** is smaller.

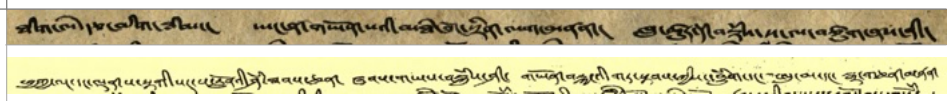
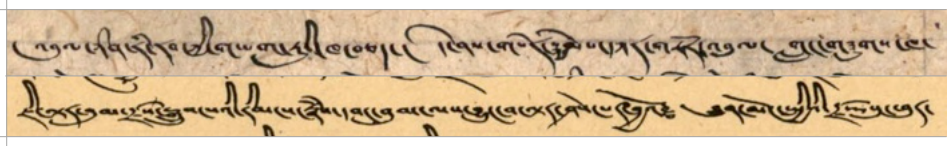
The gigu of **Tsugchung** (Small Style) is **pointier** than the previous two, with a smaller size.

Trinyig (the Epistolary Script) is mainly used for diplomatic letters, but can also be observed as a script for writing comments and notes.

Gyuyig and Khyuyig: The Running Scripts and Cursives

Yigchung: The Small Script

Gigu angle	**Upward-pointing gigu with an angle of between 45-90 degrees**
Naro	A minimalistic straight line
Overall	Small sized, swiftly scribed script

Script style	Identifier Sample
Yigchung: The Small Letters	
Tsumakhyuk/Tsumachug (Semi-Cursive)	

Yigchung or Small Letters is a running script, used for interlinears, notes, explanations, and page names. Explainers usually appearing at the end of a chapter or volume can have several pecha pages. Yigchung may look "cursive", but it does not constitute the Tibetan definition of cursive, as no letters and vowels of Yigchung are supposed to "flow" (*'khyug*) or be written with connected ligatures. So, it is a running script "Gyuyig, *rgyug yig,*" and not a Khyuyik (cursive).

The difference between true cursives and non-cursives or semi-cursives in Tibetan is whether letters, vowels, and suffixes are written with connected ligatures or not. These can be observed in the letters, ཚ tsha and ཤ sha, and the syllable སྲ, which have exaggerated strokes in running and cursive scripts like these respectively:

Small Letters:

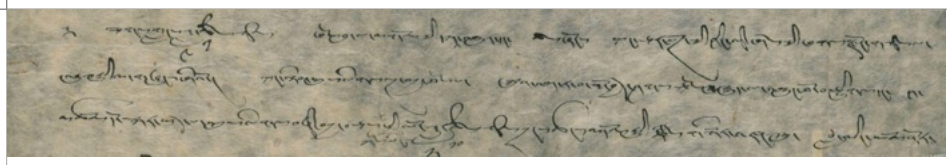
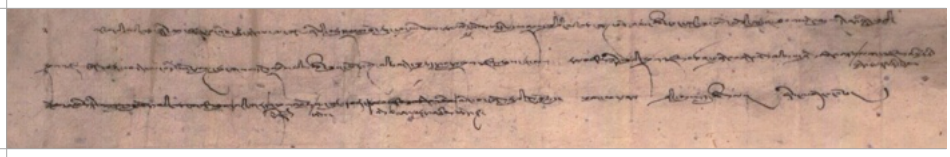
Semi-Cursive:

Cursive:

Additionally, many of the suffixes in གང་དན་མ་བ་ཟ་ས་ can be written with connected ligatures.

Khyuyig: Cursive Scripts

Gigu angle	Upward-pointing gigu with an angle of **90 degrees or more**
Naro	A straight line, that can be integrated with the root letters
Overall	

Script style	Identifier Sample
Khyuyik/Chuyig (Cursive)	
Dren (Super Cursive)	

A unique and easy-to-spot syllable that draws a clear line between a true cursive and a semi-cursive is the letter-vowel combination ཚ *tshe*. In semi-cursive, tshe remains this ཚ form, while in true cursive, it is written with this unique form. (This can be observed on both samples given above: lines 1 and 3 on the first sample, and all three lines contain it on the second sample, although the style differs from the first sample.)

The difference between Cursive and Super Cursive is the level of speed and connected ligatures. As such, in Super Cursive, the levels are maxed.

End of guide